avid admirer of their civilisation'.[25]

As for the 'misfortunate ignobles . . . no more than beasts lurking in their nests' who alleged that Akbar was claiming the place of God's messenger – or even of God! – to them, Abul Fazl quotes Akbar's own response: 'Good God! How can it enter the minds of the ignorant that a created being mired in nature could claim divinity?'[26]

And yet, it is not for nothing that Abul Fazl is one of the world's most influential writers, the creator of one of the world's most iconic portraits of a ruler. The very words he uses for the ignobles' accusation also justify Akbar's claim. These men, writes the historian, 'lurking in their nests by night and stomping about blinded by daylight accused the world lord, whose lineage became more illustrious with each succeeding generation, of claiming divinity . . .'[27]

Adam is not the only ancestor of note in Akbar's genealogy. There is also Alanqoa's union with pure light, after all. Akbar was a Niru'un; his glory would, of course, blind those accustomed to the darkness of their own unexamined traditions. Metaphors of light fill the *Akbarnama*, in fact, and not by accident; his superhuman origins are part of Akbar's claim to superhuman authority.

But the story of Alanqoa does not end with light alone. It merges, in fact, with the story – and the claim – of Akbar's increasingly illustrious lineage.

One of the many Mongol kings who descended from Alanqoa, writes Abul Fazl, had twin sons, Qabul and Qachulay; and the younger of them, Qachulay, had two dreams. In one, three stars rose to the left of his elder brother Qabul, and a fourth from Qabul's neck. In the second, seven stars rose from Qachulay's own neck, followed by an eighth of stunning brightness. Astrologers were consulted, and all agreed on the meaning of the dreams: both brothers would have illustrious sons, but at different times – Qabul after four generations and Qachulay after eight. This prompted their father to bequeath them both his rule. Qabul would occupy the throne while Qachulay wielded administrative and military power.

Traditionally, later astrologers identified Qabul's fourth star with Chinghis Khan, and Qachulay's eighth with Timur – the two brothers engendered two clans, in fact, Chingizid and Timurid, both of which were joined in Babur, born of a Chingizid mother and Timurid father.